

George Douglas Papers family reading edition

Volume V

Folder 4 correspondence

Version 2.0

September 2026

Prepared for Volney Douglas

From scans supplied by Abilene Christian University

Special Collections and Archives

A readable version in plain English, with uncertainties and damaged passages marked.

This volume accounts for all 111 scan pages of source 07. It belongs to a set covering 932 scan pages in ten source PDFs. This AI-assisted contribution is offered for review and correction.

Reading this volume

Preparation and independence

Prepared for Volney Douglas with AI assistance in September 2026. Every new scan page received an initial visual reading, with selected enlargement, rotation, contrast adjustment and comparison against related passages within the source collection. Local Apple Vision OCR was run at four orientations on all 545 new pages as a reading aid. OCR agreement alone did not establish a reading. The other agent's transcription was excluded as a source for this addition. Reference and family readings of the new pages were prepared together from the scans; they are not independent of each other. No independent human verification or ACU endorsement is claimed. The earlier version 1.1 has its own disclosed comparison history, preserved in the previous guide and review records.

Reference and family editions

The annotated reference edition preserves readable original wording, spelling, grammar and abbreviations. Ordinary prose wrapping may be reflowed; poem lines and ledger groups are retained. Capitalization, punctuation and word division sometimes require judgment. Superscripts are generally lowered; raised numbers in the convivial journal are retained. Underlining and decorative marks are not systematically encoded. This is a direct reading transcript, not a facsimile or fully diplomatic edition. The family edition modernizes wording and explains abbreviated forms where secure. Very damaged passages sometimes receive an explicitly identified fragmentary reading rather than an invented continuous text. Financial figures remain as read and are not silently reconciled.

Uncertainty and interventions

Double square brackets identify editorial intervention. `[[word?]]` is a tentative reading; `[[illegible]]` marks unread writing, with no implied word count. `[[lost: description]]` records missing material and `[[obscured: description]]` records an obstruction. `[[deleted: text]]` and `[[inserted: text]]` distinguish readable revisions. `[[separate block: description]]`, `[[blank]]` and other descriptive markers explain layout or non-textual material. Original single brackets and question marks remain part of the source. A gap is not filled solely to make a fluent sentence or to match a related copy.

Order and evidence

The reference volumes retain PDF scan order. Editorial notes link displaced continuations and clearer related versions. The family edition also retains source-page locators, with reading-order guidance beside the relevant text. Later identifying slips remain distinct from the manuscript and may disagree with it. A name in an account does not establish kinship, ownership or parentage. Poems may use fictional speakers, aliases, satire and imagined events. Letters preserve their writers' assertions, rumors and opinions, including offensive historical language; a transcript does not verify those statements.

Locators and corrections

A page ID such as 09-003 means source 09, PDF scan page 3, counting the cover as page 1. A block ID such as 09-003-P02 identifies the second transcript block. These locators are not original manuscript page numbers. Earlier IDs are unchanged. New uncertainty IDs append U001, U002 and so on to their source-page ID. Please propose corrections with the locator, existing wording, proposed wording and supporting image evidence. The original scans remain authoritative.

Source credit

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Source record

George Douglas Papers Folder 4- Correspondence.pdf

SHA-256: d793cb8a8affd81758c51115e10bdd7b8c961840d20fcaca9978367d4d9c5914

Scan 001 07-001

Repository cover: Folder 4

Abilene Christian University's Digital Commons cover identifies this as George Douglas Papers, Folder 4—Correspondence, with the catalog date 1863. It belongs to the university's digitized manuscripts, personal papers and archival records collection. The collection link is https://digitalcommons.acu.edu/george_douglas.

Scan 002 07-002

Lizzie's letter to George in Houston, April 1863

A later identifying note labels this Letter No. 10 from sister Lizzie Douglas to brother George, April 15, 1863, concerning the lack of news from him.

The envelope is addressed to Mr. George Douglas, Company C, Griffin's Battalion, Texas Volunteer Infantry, Houston, Texas. It bears a handwritten Red Oak, Texas, April 18 endorsement.

Scan 003 07-003

Lizzie fears for George's safety and the missing letters

Brushy, Wednesday night, April 15, 1863. Letter No. 10.

Dear Brother,

I am writing again, although I cannot promise anything very interesting. Last Saturday Laura received your March 21 letter—the first we had received for three weeks. On Sunday Lou received Joda's letter with your April 12 letter enclosed. We were very glad, because we did not know whether you had left Galveston.

I hope your new posting is healthy and pleasant, though I fear it will be less so than the one you left. Do you think you could be attacked so far inland? It seems a curious place for soldiers. I fear you will not stay there long, but will keep being sent onward until you reach the Mississippi, where you might be trapped like the prisoners at the Post, or suffer a worse fate.

You cannot imagine how worried we were when we had no news. We thought of so many reasons why letters had not arrived. Perhaps someone had read some of your letters, or some of—

Reading note. The sentence continues on the next scan page. Lizzie's fears and predictions describe her state of mind; they do not establish George's orders or what actually happened.

Scan 004 07-004

Mother's fears, Lizzie's request to burn letters, and farm work

—my letters to you, and perhaps something dreadful had happened to you. You might have carelessly left them lying around. Who knows how much treason someone might find in our unpopular ideas? That was Mother's reasoning; only time could show whether she was right. I know you will smile at this, but remember how easily frightened we become when anything unusual happens.

Mother has also warned me to be careful what I write in these dangerous times. While I remember, Beck told us she found several of my old letters in Warren's trunk. After you have read my letters as much as you like, would it not be better to burn them in your campfire? They will make the fire burn a little higher, then settle down and cause no trouble.

After hoeing hard all day, carrying a bucket of water from the main spring and milking the cows—we have six young calves in the pen—I feel very tired. Hoping you are not on guard tonight, I will say goodnight and retire.

April 16. It is a beautiful evening. A strong southern breeze has blown away the clouds that hid the sun this morning.

Closing written in the upper margin:

Everyone here on Brushy is well. No more for now. Affectionately, Lizzie.

Reading note. “Treason” is the family’s feared interpretation of their private letters. The passage does not specify a charge, prosecution or particular political position. It also directly records Lizzie’s hoeing, water carrying and milking.

Scan 005 07-005

Good crops, furloughs, and a sister’s wish for peace

—and left the sky clear and bright. Spring has brought good growing weather, so everything looks well. Father happened to plant his six acres of corn just before a heavy rain. It has come up beautifully, with hardly a missing planting. Mr. Graves did less well and had to replant a good deal.

Cousin Gran came home on April 4 with sixty days’ leave. He seems born lucky: this is his second sixty-day leave since they all went to Arkansas. Being married appears to help him get leave. Lambert Pace has been sick for a long time and has tried to come home, but at the last report he still had no permission—because he is unmarried, I suppose. Joda writes that he expects to come home around mid-May. You say nothing about coming, so I suppose you have no chance.

I hope, trust and pray to our heavenly Father that this cruel war will soon end and you can return to us. Guard against the temptations around you, so that you return with stronger qualities of mind—and body, too—which, when—

Partly unreadable upper-margin note:

I suppose Bill Willis is nearly ready to leave for the army now, as his “Little black *[[unreadable]]*”; I do not know whether it *[[missing text]]* or not.

Reading note. Lizzie’s suggestion that marriage determined leave is explicitly her speculation. The damaged margin is retained rather than supplied with an inferred meaning.

Scan 006 07-006

Lizzie’s hopes for George’s character, hay, relatives and cloth

—developed, make a person honorable, just and good, worthy to be the work of the divine *[[unreadable]]* and to call the infinite Creator Father. When called back to dust, such a person may leave the animal creation seeming unworthy to be the work of the same Being. I fear few will emerge from this terrible, soul-testing scene of wickedness and confusion unharmed and pure. But I think some will, and may my brother be among them, returning home as bright examples of virtue and Christian character.

The sun is sinking behind the western hills, reminding me to stop writing. Just a few more things: Uncle Jeff is sowing Hungarian grass north and west of the house, in the old wheat ground. Father sowed four acres of grass last week, and a good rain has fallen since. Uncle Jeff says Joda’s and Joda’s wheat is the best he has seen in the country. I wish we had some of it in the field.

I have not been to church for two months, so I cannot tell you anything about the Red Oak girls.

Cross-written addition:

Mother says paper is becoming scarce, so we will have to shorten our writing. I will try that this time and see *[[unreadable]]*. *[[Name unreadable]]* was over *[[unreadable]]* last Sunday and said she would write to you in a few days. Mary Graves is *[[partly unreadable]]*. She is only half an inch shorter than I am. You know she was two inches shorter when we all measured ourselves on the last day in *[[Lewisville?]]*. I am glad you are gaining weight, but do not become so big that we fail to recognize you when you return.

We have not heard from Aunt Jane since she went home. I wrote to her more than a month ago. Lou has written a letter that we will post tomorrow. If you have received any letters from her, let us know.

Partly unreadable margin:

We plan to make cotton cloth to sell, if we can sell it. We have made a bale of *[[domestic cloth?]]*. The remaining words concern sending something, but cannot be read confidently.

Reading note. The repeated “Joda and Jodas” is retained; it is not changed to two inferred names. The cross-written paragraphs and margin contain unresolved passages.

Scan 007 07-007

Later note identifying Lizzie's April 4 letter

A later note identifies the following letter as Lizzie Douglas's letter to brother George, dated April 4, possibly 1863. It mentions worry over the lack of news, Warren's return and Mrs. Payne's death.

Scan 008 07-008

Lizzie reports Mrs. Payne's death and worries over the mail

Saturday night, April 4 [year not stated; possibly 1863].

Dear George,

Warren's visit is nearly over, since he leaves tomorrow. I thought I would write a few lines to tell you that we are all up and about. We have had no letter from you for about two weeks. I cannot understand why, unless you have been stopped from writing; I hope that is not the case.

This evening we were saddened to hear that Mrs. Payne has died. Poor woman, leaving her little children to face an unkind world without a mother's loving care. There are five children, including a one-week-old baby. Preston is home now, though of course he will soon have to return to the army.

Reading note. The letter reports the death and children but does not give Mrs. Payne's first name. Preston's relationship to her is not explicitly stated in this passage.

Scan 009 07-009

Cotton socks, medicine, and longing for the family to reunite

We are sending you two pairs of socks, some pills and a fine comb. I wish we could send something else, but I have thought about it and cannot think of anything else that would help you. You seemed to like the cotton socks Ellen gave you, so we knitted more, thinking they would be more comfortable in summer. If you do not like them, I suppose you have enough wool socks until we can send more.

Sister is visiting, and Warren is here. With you and Joda here too, things would feel as they used to. I hope the time comes when you can be with us again, but if you have gone east, I fear it will be a long wait. I sent you a long letter in yesterday's mail, so I have no more interesting news tonight.

Your sister, Lizzie.

Scan 010 07-010

January 1863 letter from Lizzie, addressed to Houston

An envelope addressed to Mr. George Douglas, Company C, Griffin's Battalion, Texas Infantry, Houston, Texas, bears a Red Oak, Texas, January 31 endorsement.

A later note identifies the letter as from sister Lizzie at Brushy, January 22, 1863.

Scan 011 07-011

Lizzie waits for letters and reports deaths near Brushy

Brushy, Texas, January 22, 1863.

Dear Brother,

I am writing a few lines again, though I cannot promise anything very interesting. I have sent you four letters and have yet to receive a line from you. We have looked anxiously for letters all week, but none have come. Laura went to the post office this evening. I was sure we would receive one, but we were disappointed again. I partly blame the mail, because surely you are writing. Your latest letter that we have is the January 7 one to Mary Orr.

Everyone on Brushy is well except Father, who has a headache. Death has visited our neighborhood again: Eliza *[[Andrews?]]* died last Sunday morning. Lizzie D. is slowly improving. I forgot to tell you in my last letter that Dr. Burkhardt died about—

Unclear marginal remark:

Do you get enough to eat? Your health is always better, as if you were hungry *[[unreadable ending]]*.

Reading note. This page reports local deaths but does not establish exact death dates independently. The unclear marginal sentence is not smoothed into an invented message.

Scan 012 07-012

Weddings, sickness, prices, and wartime rumors

—a month ago. There have been two weddings farther up the country since you left: Miss Betsy Branson married a Mr. King, and Miss Ellen Branson married Mr. Sam Earl. Perhaps you know Sam Earl; he belongs to Deal's company and was home sick.

[[Granite?]] is also home sick. I have not seen him. He told Father he thought he had been poisoned—perhaps by dead *[[unreadable]]*. We have no recent news of Mr. Orr's boys, or from anywhere else. It is a dull time. A person called *[[goozy?]]* came by the other day. Father asked whether he had news. He said he had heard that *[[Hymiman?]]* had taken Galveston, but he did not believe it himself.

I seldom go to church now and do not often see the girls, so I cannot tell you anything about them. Jeffie has just returned from San Antonio. He is well and says everything is as expensive there as here. We received a letter from Beck today saying that Captain Burns's brother had been killed by Federal troops within sight of his own house.

I suppose you have heard about it. Your sister, Lizzie.

Reading note. The military reports are secondhand news repeated in the letter. The unclear names remain open rather than being matched to people from outside sources.

Scan 013 07-013

Later note on Lizzie's February 1863 letter

A later note identifies Lizzie Douglas's February 10, 1863 letter to George. It summarizes news from Henry Orr about fighting in the White River area of Arkansas. It says Henry wrote from Pine Bluff on January 21 and 23 to Jim and Cynthia Orr. Fayette's and Jim Orr's fate was still unknown; they had last been seen in a rifle pit on the first day of fighting. The annotator crossed out Little Rock and substituted Pine Bluff.

Scan 014 07-014

Typed copy: news of Aunt Rebecca and the missing soldiers

Letter No. 9, Tuesday night, February 10, 1863.

Dear George,

Your February 1 letter arrived this evening. The letter, map and everything were very interesting. Ellen was delighted with her letter and has asked us to read it to her at least ten times tonight. You must write her another. Getting a letter does her as much good as it does me. Your January 25 letter arrived a week ago today. I will answer both in this letter, adding entries on successive days.

I do not think we have told you the news of Aunt Rebecca Hymann's family. As Jessie returned from Arkansas, he camped with a man who had just come from Mississippi. The man said Federal troops had overrun her neighborhood, destroyed her farm and taken her house for a hospital. Her boys were all in the army, or had been. Henry was home because he had been wounded at Fort Donaldson [the typed copy adds a question mark].

Mollie O., Sue, Laurer and I went to hear Parson Austin last Sunday. He spoke about the Millennium. I suppose it was a good talk, but I did not understand much of it. When we came home, we heard that Mr. Orr had received a letter from Henry. We ate a few bites and went to see it. Dated January 21 and 23, it said they had been at Pine Bluff only a few days. They had hurried out of the White River country, leaving cooking utensils scattered from Brownsville to Little Rock because their teams were too exhausted to pull them. We still do not know what happened to Fayette and Jim. Henry had spoken with several men who escaped, who told—

Reading note. This text survives here as a typed copy. The report about Rebecca's farm passed through a traveler and Jessie before reaching the writer. Names and military details have not been independently confirmed.

Scan 015 07-015

Typed copy: escapes from Arkansas Post and work at the loom

—him they had seen Fayette and Jim in the rifle pits late on the first day of fighting. They were all right then. That is the latest news we have.

Wednesday night, February 11. Henry also wrote that cousin Granville had seen Jack Chappell, who escaped from Arkansas Post. Jack said he had been assigned to dig ditches. When he saw the Federal flag over the town, he left. He was heading for Little Rock and hoped to get home from there. Burdet Weatherford and John Porter are home. They say they had been assigned to help the doctor at the hospital, and left when they saw the Federal flag. Porter says he hid in nearby bushes for perhaps a day and a night. After the Federal troops took possession, men in the rifle pits kept firing. A gunboat moved farther

downriver and swept the ditches with fire. Our officers had to shout “Stop, men, stop!” before the riflemen stopped. Aunt Cynthia is very worried about Jim and Fayette.

Today we wound thread onto spools for our dresses. Tomorrow we expect to “mark” it [word in the typed copy]. Mr. Tilford is bringing our loom home tomorrow, and we expect to put our cloth into production the next day. It is eight o’clock, and everyone else has gone to bed, so I must stop.

Saturday, February 14. Your February 6 letter arrived this morning. I am glad you are well. I see I must try to lengthen my letters—spin out a longer thread, or compose a little. I never expect to become a newspaper correspondent. I do not have enough ideas to share with the public, even if I could find the language. Still, “can’t” should be in no one’s vocabulary. In future—

Reading note. The battle account is reported through other people. The typescript’s textile wording is imperfect; the plain-English reading does not claim to recover missing manuscript words.

Scan 016 07-016

Typed copy: criticism of military authority and a plea for peace

—I will try to make my letters more interesting.

You ask what I think of the opinions your commander expresses. To say the least, they are arbitrary, unjust and tyrannical. If people like that gain power, what happens to our liberty and our rights as thinking people? Gone—gone forever!

I am sorry you serve under someone with so little feeling and humanity, so intent on imposing his opinions. If he believes what he says, that is bad enough; if he does not, I despise his principles and consider him unfit for his position. If he saw this letter, he would probably be more convinced than ever that correspondence should stop between the “utensils” of war and their supposedly worthless friends at home. I hope he never receives a higher command, but is reduced to an ordinary private. Then let him tyrannize over anyone he can.

We cannot hope for peace while the North continues its campaign and the South its stubborn resistance. If only those in power would stop and think what this struggle is for, and why the blood keeps flowing. But they do not. The love of power is strongest, and everything must serve it. We cannot stop it; we can only be carried along by this great current and trust Providence to bring us safely through. I pray that peace returns soon.

It is Saturday night, my usual time to write to you. Sue, Laura and I are writing; Mother is knitting; Father and the children are in bed.

Reading note. This forceful political passage is read from a later typed copy in the scan. The commander is unnamed; the text alone cannot identify him or establish the exact policy that prompted the criticism.

Scan 017 07-017

Typed copy: sickness at home and uncertainty after a lighthouse fight

Brushy, May 7, 1863.

Dear George,

Laura is sick, so it falls to me to write again this week. We were getting ready for church last Sunday when her stomach became upset. She was quite ill until this morning. Now she can sit up a little and hopes to write this evening. Everyone else is well except me: I woke dizzy this morning. [The typed copy has an unreadable or omitted passage marked with question marks, ending with “further sickness.”]

Your letter covering the 8th through the 15th arrived the day I posted my No. 12. Laura received your letter of the 16th and 17th that same day. Hers was written just before the lighthouse fight reported in the Telegraph, so we were anxious for your next letter to learn whether you and Joda took part. If so, I hope you were unharmed; the paper reported no wounded on our side.

We very much hope you have not been sent to Louisiana. Troops will presumably have to remain at Sabine, and since you are there, perhaps you will stay. But orders seem to send men one way today and somewhere entirely different tomorrow. Stone's regiment had traveled toward the frontier for three or four days when the order was reversed and they were sent to Louisiana. We heard that about four hundred refused and a serious disturbance nearly followed. I cannot say how true that report is. From what I hear, that regiment seems unreliable, and I doubt the Confederacy benefits much from its service.

Reading note. The writer explicitly questions the report of four hundred men refusing orders. The typed copy's existing gap is preserved; it has not been filled from context.

Scan 018 07-018

Typed fragment: the new loom and cloth for George

Our new loom sits in the middle of the floor, smiling at us. We set up our cloth and began weaving our dresses this evening—the ones we began spinning before you left. We have spun more besides. As soon as this cloth is finished, we have the warp ready for a piece of jean cloth. You need not worry about lacking clothes.

Reading note. Warp means the lengthwise threads set on the loom. Jeans here names a cloth, not necessarily modern denim trousers. This page supplies no date or signature. The matching manuscript at 07-025 establishes its place in the February 10–14 letter.

Scan 019 07-019

Typed fragment: hoped-for furlough and news from Johnson

If Joda receives leave to come home, we expect him in about ten days. I wish I knew you were coming with him, but I have no hope of that—otherwise I would not be writing this letter. Take good care of yourself while he is away. If you become sick, no one will be there to nurse you unless Warren returns.

Jessie arrived just after I finished last Friday's letter. Everyone in Johnson was well except Maggy and Larkin. Maggy had been very sick, but both were improving when Jessie left. He left Warren on Brick Creek.

Reading note. This is a typed fragment without its own date or signature. "Johnson" and "Brick Creek" are retained as typed, without adding a county or correcting the creek name from geography. The matching manuscript at 07-032 reads Jeffie and Buck Creek.

Scan 020 07-020

Later tentative attribution of the typed letters

A later note tentatively attributes material dated February 10 and May 7, 1863, from Brushy to Susanne Douglas Bell, writing to George Douglas. The note itself says "possibly" and includes a question mark.

Reading note. Other identifying slips attribute the February letter to Lizzie, and the surviving handwriting should be used to assess this conflict. The conflicting later notes are both preserved.

Scan 021 07-021

Lizzie lists the letters sent and fears Fayette and Jim may be prisoners

—hearing of *[[Harman's?]]* death, while her girls continue going to parties. She told Mr. Orr today that her children at home cause her more trouble than those in the army. Jeffie brings word that Jack *[[Shaw's?]]* wife has died.

Laura forgot to number her last letter; it was her seventh, excluding these scraps. You see, we have done almost as well as you. We wrote December 28, Laura wrote January 4, I wrote January 10 and 11, and Laura and I both wrote January 17 and 18. I wrote again January 22 and January 28, sending the pills; Laura wrote again on the 26th. Sue says you may read all her letters that contain no secrets.

I would not be surprised if Fayette and Jim are Federal prisoners now. I will write to War in a few days. Love to *[[Warren?]]*, Joda and yourself.

Liz.

Reading note. This fragment follows the thought at the end of 07-023, although it appears earlier in the scan. It does not confirm that Fayette and Jim had been captured.

Scan 022 07-022

Later note on the February 1 letter

A later note identifies a letter from sister Lizzie to George Douglas, dated February 1, possibly 1863. It notes her suggestion that Fayette and Jim might now be Federal prisoners.

Scan 023 07-023

Lizzie's Sunday visitors and a plea for a letter

Sunday night, February 1 [year not written; possibly 1863].

Dear George,

It hardly seems natural to send off a letter without including something for you, so I will scribble a few lines, though I cannot promise much of interest. Mother went to Sister's today. Laura has just come back from there and says everyone is well. They have heard from War once since he left; he traveled only seven or eight miles a day.

Rob and Nancy visited today, as did Mr. Orr, Aunt Cynthia, *[[Claray?]]* and Laura. Poor Jim had no one to talk to except Ellen and Jimmie. I know he missed you. Nancy is plump and can laugh as loudly as ever. Mrs. *[[Swann?]]* is in a great deal of trouble *[[unclear connecting word]]*—

Margin: I hope you find time to write to little me.

Upper margin: It is late now, nearly nine, and I must close.

Reading note. The thought continues on 07-021, earlier in the scan. War is the name or short form as written; it is not expanded without qualification.

Scan 024 07-024

Ellen delights in George's letter; news of Aunt Rebecca's farm

Letter No. 9, Tuesday night, February 10, 1863.

Dear George,

I received your February 1 letter this evening. The letter, map and everything were very interesting. Ellen

was delighted with hers and has asked us to read it to her at least ten times tonight. You must write her another. A letter does her as much good as it does me. Your January 25 letter arrived a week ago today. I will answer both by adding entries to this letter on successive days.

I do not think we have told you the news of Aunt Rebecca *[[Hymann's?]]* family. When Jeffie was returning from Arkansas, he camped with a man just arrived from Mississippi. The man said Federal troops had overrun her neighborhood, destroyed her farm and taken her house for a hospital. Her boys were all in the army, or had been. Henry was home because he had been wounded at Fort *[[Donelson?]]*.

Reading note. This is the manuscript reading. The earlier typed copy in the scan uses Jessie for the traveler; the manuscript appears to read Jeffie. News of Rebecca's family remains a secondhand report.

Scan 025 07-025

Prayer for peace and the new household loom

—this stream of blood continues to flow. But no, they do not think of this. The love of power is stronger than anything else, and everything must serve it. We cannot stop it. We can only move along with this vast current and trust Providence to bring us safely through. I pray that peace will soon smile on us again.

Saturday night, my usual time for writing to you, has come again. Sue, Laura and I are all writing. Mother is knitting; Father and the children are in bed. Our new loom sits smiling at us in the middle of the floor. We set up our cloth and began weaving our dresses this evening—the ones we began spinning before you left. That is not all we have spun since then. We have the warp ready for a piece of jeans fabric as soon as this cloth is finished. You need not fear that you will lack clothes.

Reading note. The scan places this final leaf immediately after the opening page. It belongs after 07-029. "Jeans" refers to cloth here.

Scan 026 07-026

Henry's letter and uncertain news of Fayette and Jim

Mollie O., Sue, Laura and I went to hear Parson Austin last Sunday. He explained his views of the Millennium. I suppose it was a good talk, but I did not understand much of it. At home we learned that Mr. Orr had a letter from Henry, so we ate a little and went down to hear it. It was dated January 21 and 23. They were at Pine Bluff and had been there only a few days. They had left the White River country in a hurry. Henry said their cooking utensils were scattered between Brownsville and Little Rock because the exhausted teams could no longer pull them.

We have not learned Fayette and Jim's fate. Henry had spoken to several men who escaped. They said they saw Fayette and Jim in the rifle pits late on the first day of the fight, all right then. That is our latest news of them.

Wednesday night, February 11: Henry also wrote that cousin Granville had seen Jack Chappell, who had escaped from Arkansas Post—

Later receipt note: Received February 20, 1863.

Scan 027 07-027

Escapes from Arkansas Post and preparations for weaving

—He said he had been assigned to dig ditches. When he saw the Federal flag over the town, he left. He was heading toward Little Rock and hoped to get home from there. *[[Burdett?]]* Weatherford and John Porter have reached home. They say they had been assigned to help the doctors at the hospital and also left as soon as they saw the Federal flag.

Porter says he hid in nearby bushes for perhaps a day and a night. After the Federals took possession, men in the rifle pits kept firing at them. A gunboat moved farther downriver and swept the ditches with fire. Our officers had to shout, “Stop, men, stop!” before the riflemen stopped. Aunt Cynthia is very worried about Jim and Fayette.

Today we wound thread onto spools for our dresses. Tomorrow we expect to prepare the warp. Mr. Tilford is bringing our loom home tomorrow, so we expect to put the cloth in the following day. It is eight o’clock; I must stop because everyone else has gone to bed.

Reading note. Accounts of the fighting and escapes are reports relayed to the letter writer, not her own observations.

Scan 028 07-028

Lizzie’s reply to the opinions of George’s commander

Saturday, February 14.

Your February 6 letter arrived this morning. I am glad you are healthy. I see that I must lengthen my letters—spin a longer thread, or try to compose a little. I cannot hope to become a newspaper correspondent. My mind is not full enough of ideas to communicate to the public, even if I had the words to do it. But “can’t” should be in no one’s vocabulary, so I will try to be more interesting.

You ask what I think of the opinions your “Leader” expresses. At the very least, they are arbitrary, unjust and tyrannical. If such minds gain power and control, where will our liberty and our rights as rational beings be? Gone—gone forever!

Scan 029 07-029

An angry response to military censorship and a longing for peace

Page 5.

I am sorry you serve under someone with so little feeling and humanity, and such tyrannical opinions—if he really means what he says. If he does not, I despise his moral principles and think him unfit for his position.

If he read this, he would probably be more convinced than ever that correspondence should stop between the “utensils” of war and their equally worthless friends at home. About the only good I wish him is that he never rises to higher command, but sinks to the position of one of the lowest “high privates.” Then let him tyrannize over whoever he can.

We cannot hope for peace while the North continues its present undertaking and the South maintains its stubborn resistance. Oh, if only those in power would stop and think what this conflict is for—why—

Receipt note: Received February 20, 1863.

Reading note. The sentence continues on 07-025. The contemptuous description of soldiers as “utensils” is quoted by the writer in criticizing the unnamed commander.

Scan 030 07-030

Later identification of the May 7 letter and Susanna's note

A later identifying note describes a May 7, 1863 letter from sister Lizzie Douglas at Brushy to George Douglas. It mentions the lighthouse fight and notes a passage referring to Black people. It also identifies a note to Joda Bell from his wife, Susanna Douglas Bell.

Scan 031 07-031

Laura is ill; the family waits for news of the lighthouse fight

Brushy, May 7, 1863.

Dear George,

Laura is ill, so it is my turn to write again this week. We were preparing to go to church last Sunday when she developed a sick stomach. She has been quite ill since then, but this morning she can sit up a little and thinks she may write this evening. Everyone else is well except me. I woke feeling dizzy. *[[A line about her health is lost at a fold.]]*

I received your letter of the 8th through the 15th on the day I mailed my No. 12. Laura received yours of the 16th and 17th that day too. Hers was written just before the lighthouse fight reported in the Telegraph, so we are anxious for your next letter to learn whether you and Joda took part. If you did, I hope you are unhurt. The newspaper mentioned no wounded on our side.

We hope very much you have not been sent to Louisiana. Troops will presumably have to stay at Sabine, and perhaps you will remain there. It is uncertain: soldiers are ordered in one direction today and sent somewhere entirely different tomorrow. Stone's regiment marched toward the frontier for three or four days before its orders were reversed and it was sent to Louisiana. We have heard that about four hundred men refused to go and there was nearly a rupture, but I cannot say how true that report is. From what I hear, the regiment is made of unreliable material, and I doubt whether its services benefit the Confederacy much.

If Joda gets leave, we expect him home in about ten days. I wish I knew you were coming too, but I have no hope of it—otherwise I would not be writing. Take good care of yourself—

Reading note. The letter reports a lighthouse engagement; it does not establish that George or Joda participated. The troop-refusal story is expressly a rumor.

Scan 032 07-032

Wool, harvest labor and news from Johnson County

—while Joda is away. If you become sick, no one will be there to nurse you unless Warren returns. Jeffie arrived just after I finished last Friday's letter. Everyone in Johnson was well except Maggy and Larkin. Maggy had been very sick, but both were better when he left. He left Warren on Buck Creek. Warren planned to start for camp early this week and may arrive before this letter, with all the Johnson County news.

Jeffie brought about ninety pounds of wool from Henry's. That will keep us busy until we can get it *[[missing words]]* for the carding machine. Jeffie plans to run his reaper during the harvest. He never

reported for enrollment and has not been bothered yet. I hope he will not be: he will leave everyone else alone if they leave him alone. He bought a nice little pump while up there; he says it moves *[[uncertain verb]]* like a rocking cradle.

It is a beautiful day, with a cool north wind, bright sunshine and everything green. I need not dwell on nature's beauty, since you can now see trees and vegetation instead of the waste around you on the island. The good weather is welcome after such a wet spring. The wheat had a little rust. I wish you could see Jim's wheat—it looks so fine, some reaching Jeffie's chin. Birds are eating some of it now.

Harvest is near. The Becketts and Lemmons talk of cutting this week, but ours will take another two or three weeks. I hardly know how people will save their grain unless men get leave. There are surely too few men here to harvest it all.

I have been out finding dewberries for Laura. They are scarce because nearly all the prairie has been plowed. Our garden looks well. We have plenty of mustard greens, lettuce and radishes, and expect plenty of beans, peas, squashes and tomatoes. We planted many onions, but they are not doing well.

Margin, May 8: Laura is better this morning.

Scan 033 07-033

Reported death of Robert Jetton; Lizzie's political views

Mr. Orr recently received a letter from Mr. Dyer. Dyer writes that John says cousin Robert Jetton died in Mississippi. He says three of Uncle Louis's boys were captured at Fort Donelson, exchanged, and back in Tennessee when he left. John Jetton had never entered the army because he was unable to serve. I think John Orr is mistaken about three of Uncle Louis's boys being captured; I believe only two were at Fort Donelson. Everything is hidden behind the "veil of the future." When it lifts, the picture may be sickening. Only time will tell how many people we have known since childhood will have died. Oh, if this terrible war would end and those still alive could go home.

I think enough lives have been sacrificed to satisfy the ambition of any man with a heart. But I suppose Lincoln does not care if every Southern man dies, provided he frees his beloved Black people and can rule the South. They are fighting over who will rule, not out of love for the Union. I think I would accept the rule of the Russian czar to obtain peace. Almost anything would satisfy me except freeing the Black people here among us; I think that would be more than human nature could bear. If Lincoln intends to make us equal, I want the South to fight him until he abandons the idea, then take him and force him to serve as an enslaved person for the rest of his life.

All hope of foreign intervention seems gone. We must fight until one side gives up or the other is conquered. I hope we are not conquered: I do not think a conquered people could be happy. Imagine a standing army over us to suppress rebellion. Even if we win independence, would that independence be desirable? We would have a standing army to support and a term of compulsory service if our president could carry out the views he expressed before the Mississippi legislature.

Margin: Aunt Jane wrote recently. She and the children were well, and she said she had received a letter from you shortly before.

Reading note. These are Lizzie's views, including her opposition to emancipation and racial equality. Her accusations about Lincoln's motives are opinions, not established facts. News of Robert Jetton and the prisoners is relayed through several people; she herself questions the reported number.

Scan 034 07-034

Local marriages and Susanna's hope that Joda will come home

"Of two evils, choose the lesser." But as I said, almost anything would be better than war.

You may be tired of this letter before you finish it, so I will add just a few items. Someone has married! You may wonder who is left to marry in wartime. It is George Clayton and Livinia Andrews. After a seven-year engagement, they have finally married, but I hear he is still not ready to take her home. He must go to his tanyard, prepare a house and spend another two months getting ready, according to the report. Surely seven years should have been enough? I think so.

Don Weatherspoon says Lizzie Chapman challenged her father to bring his wife there, so Old Grady has gone to live at his wife's house. The report is that Ed and Lizzie bought the home place from their father. One last piece of gossip, if you call it that: Aunt Bettie Goodloe has another daughter. That is probably enough for you this time. I must find more dewberries for Laura. Goodbye for now.

Affectionately, Lizzie.

Susanna's added note:

Dear Joda,

I expect you home by May 18, so I will not write a long letter this week. In case you do not come, I am adding a few words to Lizzie's letter. Your letter through George gave me great hope of seeing you soon. My only fear is that you have already been ordered to Alexandria. If so, I will not expect you until the war ends, because I know you would come if you could. My health remains very good, although Emmie has been unwell ever since the colic I wrote about. Lizzie has probably given you all the news. If I receive a letter saying you are not coming, I will write immediately. Hoping to see you soon, I remain your devoted wife,

Susanna Bell.

Scan 035 07-035

Later identification of Lizzie's April 2 letter

A later note identifies a letter to George Douglas from Lizzie at Brushy, Texas, dated April 2, 1863.

Scan 036 07-036

Flooded roads delay the mail and spoil a church gathering

Letter No. 9. Brushy, Texas, April 2, 1863.

Dear Brother,

It has been nearly two weeks since we received a letter. We are anxious to hear where you are, since your last letter said you would soon leave Galveston. Perhaps high water has delayed the mail.

Last Saturday and Saturday night it rained very hard—in some places harder than the great rain of February 25, though less heavily here on Brushy. Many people were disappointed about the quarterly church meeting. Uncle Joe's family had prepared for three weeks. Prudence was making elaborate arrangements for visitors, and almost everyone was getting ready. Then the clouds that had hung gloomily over us emptied their stored rain, making many faces just as gloomy. The "magnificent meeting," as Mrs. [[Thos. ?]] Hillin called it, became a "sublime failure."

I would have gone Sunday despite the mud and water, but the horses kept completely out of sight. Only Jenny, our new mare, was around, and you know I could not go alone. Mary Orr had spent almost a week making a new dress and was very disappointed. Ann Kelly had packed all her ribbons, ready to come down here, so there was certainly a “tempest in the teapot” there.

The Miss Bransons from *[[Four?]]* Mile reached Uncle Joe’s before the rain, so a few visitors attended. The Miss *[[Farrars?]]* from Chambers Creek were there too, as was Mr. Duate, whose health has *[[word clipped]]* and who intends to return to the army soon. I must continue—

Reading note. The source calls this Letter No. 9 despite using the same number for February 10. Names at the lower edge remain uncertain or clipped.

Scan 037 07-037

Warren’s brief visit and four long months of separation

We were very happy when Warren and Beck arrived last Tuesday evening. Warren has nearly recovered, though he has not regained all his strength. They cannot stay long because he wants to return to the army early next week. They must leave for home on Sunday. We are sorry: we had expected a visit of at least three or four weeks. But the cry is “To arms!” and every man who can drag one foot after the other must go.

We have no recent news. News may stand still, but the war does not. I cannot imagine why people hoped for peace by March 1, June 1 or July 1. I have lost hope of an early peace. If Lincoln intended peace, he would not be enrolling men from twenty to forty; and I think the South will not give up while it can muster a thousand men.

Three in the afternoon. I have felt unwell and tried to nap. I am a little refreshed and will write more, though I fear it will not interest you. The rest of the family is well, and the neighborhood is generally healthy except for Mrs. Payne. She is very ill and may not recover. Some of us must go sit up with her tonight.

Sis Bell stayed last night, her first visit since you left—exactly four months ago today. Four long months: they feel more like a year. Neither Lizzie Bell nor Jennie has visited since you left. They say they cannot find time, though they find time to go everywhere else—

Scan 038 07-038

A verbal map of the farm and spring wildlife

I will not quarrel with them. If they do not want to come, I do not want them to. But it hurts when people I have always considered friends seem so distant. They are friendly when we meet and beg me to visit, yet I cannot think people sincere when they offer only words and no action.

Enough of that; perhaps I can find something more interesting. Father finished planting his six acres of corn last week—or rather, Walker did. The rain should help, if we can get it cultivated.

You may like to know how the fields are divided. Starting at the west end, Mr. Graves has the ground Penae Nave and Walker worked last year. Next, Mr. Dawkins has fourteen acres, including the dewberry patch. Uncle Alf has perhaps four or five acres; I am not sure. That brings us to the wheat. Father has reserved ground just west of your wheat for Hungarian grass. Then comes the corn. The ground between the corn and the house, and between the house and the Graves field, is uncultivated—about ten acres for the weeds, I think.

Today has been beautifully clear, with a south wind and enough warmth to leave both doors open. The cottonwoods have enough leaves to give substantial shade. Wild animals are becoming plentiful. Going out to milk the other morning, I saw an animal in the low ground south of the calf pen. I could not tell whether it was a fox or wildcat, and I did not follow to learn its exact identity.

Margin: Mother stayed with Mrs. Payne last night. She is no better.

Scan 039 07-039

Deer, conscription and a bitter observation about slavery

Friday, April 3. I became so sick yesterday evening that I had to stop writing. I feel much better this morning and think I will recover. I was not very sick at first, but the medicine made me much worse. Everyone else is well. Ellen has just asked me to tell Uncle George, “Just one more letter.”

I began telling you about the wildlife yesterday. The deer are almost tame. On my way to the post office, three circled me about fifty yards away, holding up their heads and looking at me boldly as they trotted along. Turkeys seem scarce. I have heard only one or two gobble and have seen just one group of six across the creek. Rob and his brother-in-law Parks followed them. A gun awakened the echoes that evening—the first such sound for many days.

I am very glad Rob was exempted from conscription. He is a good man, useful to the neighborhood, and had nothing to do with starting these troubles. Yet many equally innocent men suffer alongside those responsible. It is useless now to debate who caused the war, since we are all caught in it, but one cannot help thinking. Graves and his whole family are at home while you are away fighting for the people he enslaves. *[[The next phrase reads “a person can deny it looks hard”; its intended sense is uncertain.]]* Still, I must not be ungrateful: Mr. Graves took an interest in having our ground cultivated. I should not call him the only one, since Rob would probably have taken some if Graves had not.

Perhaps I should stop asking questions, since you were teased so much about my earlier ones. They must have been short of conversation to joke about that. I wish you could play a good joke on the captain. Tell him old Mrs. Partington sighed when she read that he carried all his wounded men out of the fight himself, and thought, “No wonder the poor little delicate man fell into the water when that ‘*[[counchie?]]*’ shoulder’ cried, ‘Oh, my sisters, if you don’t take us away from here we will all be killed!’”

Excuse this letter if it shares some of my sickness; I still feel rather bad. Do not tell Evans what Mrs. Partington said unless it makes a good joke at his expense. With love to you and Joda, affectionately, Lizzie.

Reading note. The passage about Graves criticizes the unequal burdens of the war and explicitly connects George’s service to slavery. It does not establish that Lizzie opposed slavery; her May letter expresses opposition to emancipation. The closing joke includes comic, nonstandard wording whose precise reference remains uncertain.

Scan 040 07-040

Later identification of a January 28 letter

A later note identifies a January 28, 1863 letter to brothers Warren and George from sisters Laura Douglas and Sue Douglas.

Scan 041 07-041

Laura's January letter: rain, anxious mail visits and war rumors

In the little room, January 28, 1863.

Dear brothers Warren and George,

Your letter of the 18th arrived yesterday at noon. We are so anxious for news that someone goes to the post office twice a week. We are almost always there on the day your letters arrive, usually Tuesday or Friday, rain or shine.

It has rained heavily for three weeks—through two entire Sundays and during the weeks as well. Yet our well has not improved; I think it is beyond cure. Everyone else's wells are full. The creek runs briskly and the wheat looks fairly good after the dry autumn. Rain and a little snow have softened the ground. We have had more rain than at any time since last spring, and all the hog wallows are full. The drought seems over. If so, perhaps better times are coming. War and famine go together; if famine ends, will the war end soon? I hope so.

Today I heard that Lincoln had been shot and killed in his carriage. I cannot believe it, although it might be true. I wish it were if that would end the war. Perhaps another person in power would improve matters. Better or worse, we must endure it.

There is no recent news from Arkansas; all were well at last report. *[[Darnell's?]]* regiment has started east of this river toward Vicksburg. Whether they can cross is uncertain because the river is full of gunboats. Nashville has not been retaken; Memphis has, according to the news here. *[[Hamman?]]*, *[[Brinn?]]* and Loyd were killed in that fight, and several others wounded whose names I do not know. Our acquaintances fall one by one. *[[Three?]]* from the Lancaster company have been killed and several others have died. Will half return?

Beck's letter of the 10th said everyone was well and doing well. She had received no letters about the fight. Mr. Evins has not yet come for the corn—

Reading note. This reproduces Laura's uncertain wartime reports. The story of Lincoln's death is a false rumor dated January 1863. Her claims about military movements and captured towns have not been independently verified here. The final paragraph continues in the overlapping scan at 07-042.

Scan 042 07-042

Overlapping view: war news and the horses

[[Opening clipped.]] All were well at last report. *[[Darnell's?]]* regiment has started east of this river toward Vicksburg, but gunboats may prevent the crossing. Nashville has not been retaken; Memphis has, according to the news here. *[[Hamman?]]*, *[[Brinn?]]* and Loyd were killed, and several others wounded. Our acquaintances fall one by one. *[[Three?]]* from the Lancaster company have been killed; others have died. Will half come back?

Beck's letter of the 10th said all were well and doing well. She had no letters about the fight. Mr. Evins has not come for the corn. You asked about our old mare. She is improving and looks much better with corn and hay. Florence, my pony, is looking—

Reading note. This view overlaps 07-041. Its new material concerns the horses and continues on 07-043. The military reports remain unverified hearsay.

Scan 043 07-043

Laura's pony, neighborhood parties and fears about conscription

—somewhat better too. I am independent about riding now, with a pony at my command and only my own convenience to consider. He is regularly drilled for cavalry service and knows how to jump ditches and gullies, wheel right and left, and charge.

There have been several disreputable parties lately, one at George *[[Hoatter's?]]* and one at Hurst's. *[[Magg?]]* Lemmon attended against her mother's wishes and danced at both. Hurst's party was last Friday. The next day they heard of Hamman's death. The old man was in Lancaster when the news came; he got drunk, cursed and swore afterward. It is strange how people fail to restrain their passions. Some girls, reportedly *[[Lemley?]]*, got drunk at *[[Hoatter's?]]* party too.

Jim Jeffries has returned from the saltworks. He could not operate on a large enough scale to keep him out of the army, became sick and had to come home. I do not know his plans. Dallas has enrolled men up to forty who would agree to enrollment. I do not know what will happen to those who refused. Nave and Bill *[[B. Hill?]]* are the only ones I know, although I hear there are others. Nothing has yet been done or said about them. Ellis is not enrolling men yet, and I do not know when it will.

I understand there is a special legislative session. Our representative says he will press to extend the conscription limit from forty to sixty. What a glorious situation we are in! If they extend it to sixty, who will manage things at home? Prospects are gloomy. There are already scarcely enough men to provide supplies. What will the army do? I fear suffering ahead. This district barely has provisions to last until harvest. Some supplies here have been—

Reading note. Descriptions of the parties, casualties and enrollment are reports and opinions in the letter. The proposed conscription ages are retained as reported, without treating them as verified law.

Scan 044 07-044

Overlapping view: food supplies and the next harvest

[[Opening clipped.]] There is a special session, and our representative reportedly intends to press for conscription up to sixty rather than forty. What a situation! Who would look after things at home? There are barely enough men now to provide supplies. I fear future suffering.

This part of the country scarcely has enough food to last until harvest. Some has been hauled from farther down the country. Little wheat has been planted, so little will be harvested. *[[The final wording about supplying bread is unclear and cut at the edge.]]*

Reading note. This scan overlaps 07-043, then adds the sentences about supplies brought from elsewhere and the small wheat acreage. The thought continues at 07-045.

Scan 045 07-045

Orr family losses, shared carding tools and resentment over substitutes

—the country. I do not know whether the northern counties are better supplied; I fear not. We must hope for the best. We have never approached starvation, and I trust we never will.

Squire Orr has lost his son David. He has only John left, and does not know whether John is alive. John was among the Fort Donelson prisoners.

Friday, January 30 [corrected from Thursday]. I have just returned from Aunt Cynthia's. She and Mother have gone to Mrs. Crum's. Aunt Cynthia lent me her wool or cotton cards for a few days. Sam is going to the post office, so I must finish this letter and work. I spin whenever I can because I want a carpet *[[the next wording is unclear]]*. Mother and Lizzie keep my cards busy preparing our dress material. I started for Mr. *[[Gosling's?]]* this morning for turnips, but Mary could not go until tomorrow, so I will wait. Mary has grown rapidly and is taller than I am. Lizzie and Jennie have finished their cotton dresses. Our fabric is ready for the loom, and we have begun more.

Father has rented no more ground. He talks of getting Alfred Oats to cultivate some. It is clouding over; I fear another rainy Sunday, although there is no preaching next Sunday.

Ned and Stewart have spent several days at Uncle Alf's. They and Uncle Alf are here now collecting corn for their horses. Uncle Alf is in the "second Army" and has been to York's, I suppose. York has provided a substitute, so he can continue making his poison as usual. I wish men like him were obliged to go. Mean men and men with money can stay safe at home while poor men fight.

Mother sends her love to both of you. She wants every letter to count as equally addressed to you both. One matters as much as the other to us, and we think you are equally interested in home. I suppose Joda shares your—

Reading note. The correction in the source establishes Friday the 30th. The writer's criticism of substitutes and "poison" is preserved as her own language; the substance she means is not explicitly named on this page.

Scan 046 07-046

Overlapping view: Mother's equal love for both brothers

[[Opening clipped.]] Uncle Alf and the others are collecting corn for their horses. Uncle Alf is in the "second Army" and has been to York's, I suppose. York sent a substitute and can continue making his poison. I wish such men were compelled to serve. Mean men and men with money stay safe while poor men fight.

Mother sends love to both of you and wants all our letters understood as equally addressed to you both. You matter equally to us and are equally interested in home. I suppose Joda shares the letters too. Excuse me for now, and excuse the disorder of my writing: I put things down as they occur to me.

Reading note. This is an overlapping view of 07-045, with the final sentences added.

Scan 047 07-047

Letters, reused envelopes and a request for seashells

Both of you, write whenever you can. Nothing gives us greater pleasure than your letters. Affectionately, your sister Laura Douglas.

I still have no envelopes, so I must turn old ones inside out or make my own. I hope to get some when *[[Carrol?]]* goes to Cedar Hill. *[[L. D.?]]*

Sue's note:

Dear George,

Take care of yourself and go hear the preaching. Even if it is not exactly substantial gospel, perhaps there is good in those elaborate sermons. Once you are home, I know you will not have to attend if you do not want to. If you have time, gather some seashells for me on the beach and put a few in Warren's trunk for

safekeeping.
Your sister Sue.

Lizzie's note:

Well, George, I stayed overnight with Phony last night, my first visit since going to Johnson. Spinning keeps me so busy that I hardly go anywhere. Phrony now says she does not want anyone else to go to war because Granville has gone. You know she used to think everyone ought to go because he was away. Gran writes hopefully. He thinks the war will end within six months and sees brighter prospects—

Marginal continuation from the end of 07-048:

—around as grandly as ever. She is delighted that Cynthia gave her Jim, and can talk about old Branson until you would be sick of it. I have not seen the Red Oak girls lately, but, as Tom Roberson says, there is a strong likelihood that Ellen Petty and Higgins G. will marry. No more for now. Yours, Lizzie. No. 4.

Reading note. The final note is split between the main text here, the overlapping scan at 07-048 and these margins. "Gave her Jim" is preserved as an unexplained phrase; it is not interpreted as a documented transfer of ownership or proof of a particular relationship.

Scan 048 07-048

Overlapping view: Granville's hopes for peace and Lizzie's note

[[Opening clipped.]] I stayed with Phony last night, the first time since going to Johnson. Spinning keeps me too busy to visit much. Phrony no longer wants anyone else sent to war because Granville has gone, although she once wanted everyone to go for that very reason. Gran writes hopefully and thinks the war will end within six months. He sees brighter prospects for peace than at any time since it began. *[[A sentence about his hopes is awkward and its intended meaning uncertain.]]*

I had not thought of seashells before. Be sure to gather some. Mattie Lemmon flirts around as grandly as ever. She is delighted—

Fragment of the closing in the other margin: —for now, from Lizzie. Yours, No. 4.

Reading note. This overlaps 07-047 and supplies the continuation of Lizzie's note. Her final gossip continues around the margins of 07-047.

Scan 049 07-049

Later note identifying the letters about buying cloth

A later note identifies letters to Sue Douglas Bell from George Douglas and Joda Bell, dated January 26, *[[1869?]]*. The accompanying George letter is dated January 26, 1863.

Scan 050 07-050

Joda sends cloth home despite scarce food and limited money

Dear Sue,

I have worked all day *[[unclear verb]]* cotton and am too tired to feel much like writing. I have been so busy that I have not written as often as I should. Your letters arrive fairly regularly; the last took four days.

Lizzie wrote that she is pleased with her new home. She invites us to visit and eat something good. I will accept if I can get leave; otherwise I will visit on my way home. Things here are much the same: plenty to

do and little to eat. It is hard to live like this within sight of abundant flour, bacon and other supplies. I hope it will not last forever.

George and I are sending two bolts of calico with Dr. Lawrence, each containing *[[54?]]* yards. I bought them at auction for 26½ cents per yard because they were slightly damaged. I think the stain will wash out *[[the following phrase is unclear]]*. Even if you must tear off the damaged part, it will still be much—

Reading note. The yardage is uncertain. The wording about damage is not fully legible, and no exact usable quantity is inferred.

Scan 051 07-051

Cloth prices and Joda's instructions for dividing the purchase

—cheaper than buying at retail, where calico that wide sells for fifty cents a yard. We are also sending two bolts of domestic cotton cloth, described here as “upwards of sixty yards.” The wide cloth cost forty-five cents and the narrow thirty-five. It is inferior quality, but the best we could obtain at those prices. Nearly everything in the market is poor quality. I have seen one good lot of domestic cloth sold at forty-five cents in bulk, but little remains in the market.

George and I have equal shares. Half of each piece is yours, though you can divide or distribute it as you prefer. I think the dark cloth will make nice dresses. I would have sent thread too, but we spent all we could raise on this purchase. With luck, I will have money again soon; if I can get leave to come home, I will try to obtain more goods.

I will write again soon. Goodnight for now,
Joda.

Reading note. The source does not explicitly state whether the sixty-yard description applies to each bolt or both together. The figures are preserved without reconciling them to George's companion letter.

Scan 052 07-052

George writes from Houston about cold weather and short rations

Houston, January 26, 1863.

Replying to your letter of the 14th, I must hurry. It is sundown; I cannot write after dark, and I want this posted for tomorrow's mail. We have had unusually cold weather for this latitude for several days, and it continues, although no rain or sleet has troubled us this time. We have enjoyed our stove and the frequent company of friends.

Rations are about usual for this season: plenty of meal, not quite enough beef, and nothing else. Soap, sugar, molasses, vinegar and similar things have run out. We still have some of “that,” but when it is gone we must fall back on “No. one” for supplies.

This evening Chas. G. went to *[[Fox's?]]* soap factory to buy soap. The man asked whether we were soldiers and what—

Reading note. The references to “that” and “No. one” are unexplained in this leaf. They are not expanded by guesswork.

Scan 053 07-053

Free soap and a shared shipment of cloth for home

—company and unit we belonged to. *[[Some opening words are faded.]]* He gave us a bar and refused payment. Ordinary soap costs fifteen cents per pound and is plentiful everywhere except the Quartermaster and Commissary departments. Flour is still plentiful in the city, but Jeff has none to issue.

Goods are becoming somewhat more available or affordable. Domestic cloth retails at forty to sixty cents a yard, with other goods priced proportionately. Dr. Lawrence, Warren’s old Marion friend, is here. He lives at “Wax on *[[Moon?]]*” *[[location wording uncertain]]*. He has agreed to carry what Jody and I are sending: two bolts of calico and two of domestic cloth, over one hundred yards of each kind. All differ in quality. We will settle the cost between us and tell you how to divide them.

I have delivered the four bolts to Dr. Lawrence, each marked N. L. D., with the agreed price. He will carry them with his own goods, to the Widow Dennis’s below Waxahachie if I am not mistaken. We can pay without troubling you for money.

It is too dark to continue. Excuse the handwriting. *[[Goodbye?]]*
George.

Reading note. The short location phrase after “Wax” remains uncertain. The two correspondents’ cloth quantities are not silently reconciled.

Scan 054 07-054

Later identification of a letter from G. M. Beall

A later note identifies an April 2, 1864 letter from brother-in-law G. M. Beall at Brushy Creek to George Douglas.

Scan 055 07-055

An unexpected homecoming at Brushy Creek, April 1864

Brushy Creek, April 2, 1864.

Dear George,

I reached home last Sunday evening and found everyone well. I was so glad to see them. They were surprised, having just received my March 15 letter telling them not to expect me. The family looks much the same; no one seems much older. I was glad to see everyone looking so well. Ellen and Emmie have grown considerably. Little Mary is an engaging child and, I think, very pretty.

My journey home took eleven days, including a day’s delay at *[[Bren.??]]* and another at Houston. At Beaumont I heard our battalion had been ordered to Louisiana and that *[[unclear name or unit]]* were to go to Sabine Pass to relieve—

Reading note. The uncertain stop and the name of the relieving unit are not expanded by guesswork.

Scan 056 07-056

A journey through military orders and gratitude for food at home

—our battalion. The news worried me because I feared being stopped, especially as I kept seeing marching orders and men detailed to extra duty. I was uneasy until I got out of Houston. But luck was with me, and I escaped “Satan’s *[[jaws?]]*” once more in these desperate troubles *[[one word uncertain]]*.

I have enjoyed the past week very much. Whenever I sit at the table, I think of you and the other boys and wish you could share the good food. Biscuits, ham and other things look inviting at mealtimes. *[[Several words about this are uncertain.]]* I wanted to hear from you before leaving and expect a letter tomorrow. *[[About three faded lines cannot be read reliably.]]*

[[Further faded passages mention business in Texas, telling the boys, and travels.]] My respects to Dr. Davis and his wife *[[ending unreadable]]*.

Yours truly, *[[G. M. Beall?]]*.

Margin, Sunday evening: We attended preaching last night and heard a good sermon by Brother *[[Tane?]]* on First Corinthians, chapter 3 [citation corrected in the manuscript].

Other margin: Everyone is well this morning. It is a lovely morning.

Reading note. The lower part of this scan is too faded for a continuous reliable reading. The marked gaps preserve that limitation; surrounding words are not reconstructed from context.

Scan 057 07-057

Later identification of a February 15 letter

A later note identifies a letter from Susanna (Douglas) Bell to George Douglas, dated February 15 with a question mark. No year is given on the slip.

Scan 058 07-058

Father's sixty-second birthday and Sue's affectionate advice

[Corner annotation: 1863.]

Sunday morning. The wind shifted north yesterday morning, so it has probably reached you by now. It is cloudy, but I do not expect rain today. This is Father's birthday. He is sixty-two and healthier than he has been for years—because of exercise, I suppose. I will stop before this becomes a “sister Jane of a thousand words.”

Affectionately, Lizzie.

George, excuse my finishing my letter to Joda on your paper. We assume you read each other's letters, so it makes little difference. Paper and envelopes are scarce because Warrall did not go to Cedar Hill for more at the expected time. We must do the best we can.

Lizzie has written so much that I hardly know what to add. You criticize her letters rather severely, but perhaps it will help by stimulating abilities that might otherwise stay dormant. Take care of yourself and keep company with intelligent, well-disposed people. Kiss little White Lily for me, and do not forget your Emmie and little Ted.

Yours, Sue.

Reading note. The birthday passage gives an age and day, not a birthplace or parentage. February 15, 1801 is a possible calculated birth date if the February 15, 1863 dating is correct. The corner year and receipt date are distinguished from the main text.

Scan 059 07-059

Reassurance from home and an offer to send more clothes

Page 7.

Be sure to tell us when your clothes wear out, including your socks, so we can send more. I have counted

your duty schedule and think you are on guard tonight unless you are ill. You must often think of home while standing in the cold with no one to talk to. Do not become homesick: peace and your return may be nearer than we expect.

I do not remember what Laura wrote, but your letter suggests she painted a gloomy picture. That may simply reflect her mood that day; everyone sometimes feels gloomier. Here is my picture: we are all doing well and are healthy. We suffer from “consumption” only—

Receipt note: Received February 26, 1863.

Reading note. The joke continues on 07-060: “consumption” means eating, not tuberculosis in this passage. These leaves precede the concluding notes scanned at 07-058.

Scan 060 07-060

Good wheat at home and a reported death at a bridge

—at mealtimes, or whenever we are hungry! We have plenty to eat and expect enough all year. Your wheat looks as good as, or better than, any I have seen.

We have enough clothes and will continue to, as long as we are healthy enough to make cloth. Do not worry about us; we are doing well.

Mr. Crum has received a letter from Charly describing Harman’s death. They were making an infantry charge across a bridge. Harmon was struck just after crossing, either in the head or chest; Charly did not know which because he did not see him after his death. They say he uttered no word, threw out both arms and fell on his face. He was carrying \$180 and a journal kept since entering the service. These had not been recovered at that time, according to what I was told.

Reading note. The two spellings Harman and Harmon occur in this report. Charly’s account is secondhand concerning the wound, and the writer qualifies the report at its close.

Scan 061 07-061

Later note correcting the addressee to Lizzie

A later identifying note describes George Douglas’s Letter 64 from Sabine Pass, March 20, 1864. The addressee was corrected from Susanna Douglas to Lizzie Douglas.

Reading note. The later note says March 20; the manuscript at 07-062 may say March 30. Both readings remain visible.

Scan 062 07-062

George questions hopes for peace and describes wartime controls

Sister Lizzie,

Sabine, March *[[30?]]*, 1864. Letter No. 64.

The month is almost over, so I thought I would finish it with a letter a day or two earlier than usual. There is nothing especially interesting happening; I am passing the time. *[[Some words about colds are faded.]]* I have quite a *[[severe?]]* cold. Colds seem to affect me worse here than in Ellis, perhaps because the cold weather here is damper.

Do not celebrate peace too soon. People here are cautious. I expect no peace until one side is completely exhausted, and that will take time. Yesterday a report arrived that the Federals had taken Sabine Town

and its artillery battery and equipment. I cannot vouch for it, although it seems generally believed. Sabine Town is 125 miles upriver and about 100 miles west of Alexandria. Taylor's cavalry has been ordered to Louisiana and has gone. It is quiet here and the weather is good; a cold norther has passed.

Four men deserted from Bickley's company the night before last and went to the blockading ships. Some Confederates still seem drawn to life at sea. The latest act, keeping those aged eighteen to forty-five in their present units for the duration of the war, is an "eye-opener." It rather contradicts claims that all troops on the other side voluntarily reenlisted.

Everything that can be done has been done; there is some satisfaction in that. First, every able-bodied white male Confederate citizen aged seventeen to fifty is declared in military service for the war. Second, owners of fifteen able-bodied enslaved field workers as of January 1, 1864 are exempt, provided they sell all surplus provisions annually to the government at fixed prices and undertake to furnish *[[100?]]* pounds of meat *[[remaining wording unclear]]*.

Reading note. George is describing measures as he understood them; this is not a certified copy of the law. His report of Sabine Town's capture is explicitly unverified. The date differs from the later identifying slip, and the exemption's final quantity remains uncertain.

Scan 063 07-063

Civil liberties, prisoners and blockade-running news

Third, impressment officers will take whatever the army needs at government prices, wherever they find it, provided it is not everything a person owns. They give some kind of paper payment; the spirit seems to be that the kind does not matter.

Fourth, Confederate money west of the Mississippi will be taxed *[[33⅓?]]* percent after July 1 *[[following phrase unclear]]*. Fifth, habeas corpus is suspended in certain cases.

Step by step, public liberty is disappearing and personal affairs are in the government's hands *[[one connecting word unclear]]*. This is something like what might have been expected at the beginning. The way things began and ended is entirely consistent. A fuss made about nothing had to end in something. The wind blows more strongly from the South, likely to blow up a war soon.

Griffin has gone to Galveston for six days; I do not know why. Only two Howards must wear the large balls, rather than three as I said before. Jackson and Doggett are under guard for ninety days only.

I would write to W. J. C. again if I knew where to address him. They are reportedly ordered to Louisiana. It is hard to reach a cavalryman by letter while he is always marching or scouting. I have followed his addressing instructions and can do no better. Ask Hefner his rank on Howell's staff.

The steamer Isabella ran the blockade at Galveston with a large load of ammunition and arms, and a few boxes of wine for "old Mag." Several schooners have also arrived recently. Confederate money *[[remaining line unreadable]]*.

Reading note. This continues George's account of Confederate policy and his own criticism of it. The currency percentage is uncertain. "Large balls" refers to the punishment he discusses again in the January letter at 07-065–068; the text here does not specify their weight.

Scan 064 07-064

Later identification of George's January 11 letter

A later note identifies a January 11, 1864 letter from George Douglas at Sabine Pass to his sisters, with a question mark after the addressee.

Scan 065 07-065

George to his sisters: cold weather and desertion, January 11, 1864

No. 51. Sabine, January 11, 1864. Dear sisters,

Another unpleasant week has passed. Sleet fell, the ground froze fairly hard, and the wind has been damp and chilly. Today is cloudy, rain threatens, and mud is everywhere. The claim that this latitude is warm in winter is a joke. It is less cold than Ellis County, but the damp makes it more uncomfortable than dry cold. All things considered, we are doing well for soldiers and should not complain. Living in houses is much better than sleeping outdoors without tents, as the men around Lavaca must. We have enough beef and bread to live reasonably well—*[[illegible wording]]*—much better than some others.

The latest news from the east is discouraging. The Yankees are jubilant and the Confederates downcast. Everything looks dark for the Confederacy. Our armies are in bad condition, while the enemy's are the opposite. Our men all want to go home; the Yankees say they will reenlist. See the Telegraph of January 8. The militia are very homesick and intend to go home when their six months end, whatever happens. Fifty men have deserted our battalion since the big scouting expedition in December. Some are reportedly captured, but I doubt it: the report came indirectly. Eight or ten Davis Guards have also deserted to the Yankees. The company resents harsh treatment. One man was put in a ball and chain for a minor offense. They say Magruder had promised never to punish them in such a degrading way. They petitioned him to cancel the sentence, and he *[[illegible: final line faded]]*.

Scan 066 07-066

Resistance to punishment in Griffin's battalion

Since the first case, another one or three men have been put in a ball and chain. They threaten to surrender the fort to the Yankees next time unless they receive better treatment. We will see how much truth there is in this. If the Irish soldiers carry out their threat, it will be serious.

There is great discontent in the battalion. Unless someone backs down, someone will be hurt. About three months ago, two men outside Company C missed roll call. The roll had been called fifteen minutes early, before the drum sounded. Their orderly sergeant ordered them to carry guns as punishment. They refused because roll call had been held too early. They were arrested and tried for disobeying orders, then sentenced to wear a barrel "shirt" for *[[twenty days?]]*, twenty-two hours a day, followed by ten days of solitary confinement on bread and water. The barrels bore their names and the words "disobedience of orders and fatigue duty." Yesterday, when officers tried to put the barrels on them, some men in their company came out armed to resist. The barrels were too small, and larger ones arrived this morning. Meanwhile Colonel Griffin ordered the resisters into the guardhouse. They refused, and many in the battalion promised to support them. This morning they left camp for the countryside, abandoning their weapons and their cause. Griffin told the battalion that resistance to the court-martial's decree was mutiny. He would arrest everyone involved; if he lacked enough men here, he would report it to Magruder, who would use every means to arrest and punish them to the full extent of the law. *[[Uncertain word or name: Shriver?]]* Since resisting the order would be mutiny—

Scan 067 07-067

George criticizes discipline and doubts the Confederacy's future

—and the men originally involved *[[unclear opening wording]]*, the others quietly gave in and allowed them to wear the barrels. Company C showed more willingness to mutiny than the others. The colonel declared that he intended to arrest and punish the armed men who resisted yesterday. I suppose they have now left the post. I would do the same in their circumstances, though I hope I never have to mutiny. Such severe punishments for minor offenses demoralize the army. They have directly caused nearly twenty desertions and will cause many more. Griffin stands at least forty degrees below zero in his men's opinion. They despise his rigid military behavior. He rules through military law, without gentleness, treating the men much as an overseer treats enslaved people. He speaks to them only when he wants work done. That is his character, and perhaps he cannot help it. I have learned never again to join a regiment commanded by a professional military man. Everything has settled down, and I hope there will now be peace within the command.

I received your December 19 letter recently. As for Warren, he is as big a fool as ever. Like an old “hard-shell Baptist,” he will not be convinced of anything he does not want to believe. Nearly everyone else is disgusted. In my opinion, the Confederacy cannot last much longer unless a great change occurs somewhere. Something must happen soon to change the whole situation, or it is finished. Beyond what I have already said, I believe there is nothing new or interesting.

Scan 068 07-068

Impressment, defeat, and a faint hope of peace

Recent official documents suggest that the impressment law—the government's compulsory taking of supplies—is not working as expected. It seems to have caused more dissatisfaction than anticipated. Perhaps Congress will repeal it. Taking private people's belongings by force is a bad policy. If people will not support a government willingly, it must fall despite the efforts of a few. If they do not value the country enough to save it themselves, forcing them to do so is a poor policy.

You will see that the defeat at Chattanooga turns out much as I predicted. I think it will cost the Confederacy thirty thousand men, with three-quarters lost through the loss of prestige. Look at the Houston Telegraph's admissions. Abe's latest proclamation is a *[[description uncertain]]* document. As the Yankees occupy the country, people will take the prescribed oath. Guaranteed safety for themselves and their property is tempting, especially when an oath can be broken in two minutes once an opportunity arises.

Morgan's escape was clever, and no doubt John will give the Yankees plenty of trouble yet. Do you not think *[[uncertain name or pen name: View-au-Sie?]]* exaggerates his pieces? Sensational writing somehow does not count for as much as it once did.

With the slightest imaginable hope of peace this summer, I remain affectionately, George.

Scan 069 07-069

Filing slip: George to Lizzie, May 10, 1864

To Sister Lizzie from George Douglas, Manhasset, May 10, 1864.

Scan 070 07-070

George describes the march toward the gunboats, May 10, 1864

Manhasset, May 10, 1864. Sister Lizzie,

Much has happened since I last wrote. You will probably have heard the outline before this arrives, so I will give the details. Last Wednesday night we received orders to march to Calcasieu. At sundown we broke camp and went to town, where we received three days' rations of crackers and bacon. Each man carried a blanket, canteen, musket, sixty rounds of ammunition, and his food. We were ordered to sleep. *[[Part of the description of the uncomfortable sleeping place is obscured.]]* At daylight we rose and began the march.

The first six miles crossed a boggy marsh, trampled by livestock when wet and made harder to walk through by tall grass. We made a serious mistake by marching too far and too fast without rest. Several men were exhausted and had to lie down within those first six miles. We then followed a sandy ridge through a sparsely settled area where refreshments and water were plentiful. At the end of the point, twenty miles along, we stopped for the artillery. At four o'clock we resumed. About half an hour before sunset we passed the last house on the peninsula, with roughly eighteen miles still to go. *[[Some remarks about the sergeants, captain, and next six miles are unclear.]]* Around midnight we reached *[[Oyster Bay?]]*, which led to *[[illegible]]*. We slept for an hour while the sappers and *[[illegible]]* built a bridge. The gunboats were still six miles away, and water three miles away. Every canteen was empty. *[[Part of the description of thirst and grumbling is unclear.]]* At the well we found nothing with which to draw water, so we had to march on without any prospect—

Scan 071 07-071

The advance under fire

—of getting water until the fighting ended. That was a grim prospect if we were wounded. Still, we continued and reached a point half a mile from the boat at daylight. Our whole force numbered about three hundred, including *[[Creuzbaur's?]]* artillery. The battery took position, and we advanced at a run. The infantry had two divisions: three companies of *[[Spaight's?]]* battalion and Company *[[F?]]* of Griffin's, under Captain O'Brien, would attack the upper, left-hand boat. Companies *[[A?]]*, C, D, and E of Griffin's, under Major McReynolds, would attack the lower, right-hand boat. The four companies soon became mixed together, rushing forward more like a herd of cattle than disciplined soldiers. After we had gone about two hundred yards, the batteries opened fire.

The officers tried to restore the line. At "Guide right," everyone crowded toward the right guide and began moving directly between our battery and the boat. The boat had not yet fired; we later learned that our artillery fire first alerted its crew to our approach. At "Guide left," the crowd surged left together. Since everyone seemed to be commanding himself and had lost his place, I decided to be my own general. I let the crowd go and kept moving forward, sometimes behind and sometimes ahead. I knew the crowd would draw grapeshot. Shot and shell passed a few feet above me. I watched the cannon muzzles in front, dropping faster than I ever had before whenever one flashed. I continued in this way—

Scan 072 07-072

Thirst, exposed positions, and breakfast under fire

—until I was near the boat, where both falling shells and rifle bullets threatened me. As grapeshot began flying low and thick, I moved diagonally to the left to escape the line of fire, although I was still within

range. We were all within about 150 yards of the boat. Grapeshot whistled close by. Our rifle fire through the gunports became so heavy that the Federal crew could barely work their guns. They had no steam up and could not move the boat. The wheel was so exposed that no one could survive there for a minute. Rifle bullets pierced the sheet iron around the gunports. This was the situation half an hour into the fight. I was so thirsty I could barely swallow. Dozens of us lay down nearly exhausted. After resting a little, we were ordered to conserve ammunition and fire only when someone aboard exposed himself. *[[The end of this passage is unclear.]]*

Where I lay, there was more danger from behind than ahead, because our men were scattered in the grass and weeds farther back, firing. I wanted to see what was happening, but fear kept me down. About an hour later the boat swung broadside toward us, and we were ordered out of range. I stayed close to it and *[[part of the description of passing between the boat and battery is unclear]]*, then moved out of range below it. I was very hungry, so I called nearby Henry Collins to share a snack. We opened a haversack of bacon and crackers and ate a substantial breakfast in full view of the gunboats. While we ate, a cannonball cut down a weed—

[Inverted margin, concluding the letter after the margin on scan 07-073.] Three were killed on the Wave; I do not know how many were wounded. They threw their dead overboard. I cannot give a precise *[[illegible]]* now. Ten or eleven on our side were killed, and about as many wounded. Next week I will give the rest of the details. All well. Affectionately, your brother George.

Scan 073 07-073

The aftermath of the capture of the gunboats

—within ten feet of us. We went on eating, thankful it had come no closer. Afterward, we headed toward the riverbank to escape the upper boat's fire. I noticed that the lower boat had surrendered. We paused to look, and another ball from the upper boat whistled along, clipping weeds about three feet above the ground. We dropped before it reached us. It missed me by six or eight feet and Henry by about two.

We returned to the surrendered boat and found Sergeant Jones dead, with both legs broken and grapeshot through his chest. Twenty yards away lay young *[[Sprinkle?]]*, whose head had been struck by grapeshot. A shell had also badly mutilated his left arm, shoulder, and side; I think that happened after the grapeshot killed him. Ten feet away lay a man from Daly's battalion whose head had been shot off by a cannonball. Nearby, a sergeant from the same battalion, wounded in the thigh by grapeshot, called for water. Behind them was Lieutenant *[[Iglehart?]]*, also badly wounded in the thigh. Farther back lay *[[Burrell?]]* of Company *[[C?]]*, mortally wounded by grapeshot. No one had water, and I had none to give. That was the melancholy sight after our victory. The wounded men's friends were with them, and I could do nothing to help, so I turned away. Within a few minutes, water came from the boat and the wounded were carried on *[[stretchers?]]* to the hospital. There had been no shelter from the fire: only grass and weeds on ground as flat as a floor.

[Inverted upper margin.] We attacked the Granite City; Spaight attacked the Wave. The Granite had eight guns, the Wave six. They used mainly three guns against us. There were about 140 prisoners, including officers. Fourteen aboard the Granite were wounded; two have since died.

Scan 074 07-074

Filing slip: George to his sister, July 10, 1864

To his sister from George Douglas, Manhasset, July 10, 1864. No. 77.

Scan 075 07-075

Food, gardens, and artillery drill, July 10, 1864

Manhasset, July 10, 1864. No. *[[77?]]*. Dear sister,

Your June 26 letter arrived last Friday and found us all well. Things are dull, though we had a good rain recently. We manage to eat fairly well for these times: today we had fresh corn and tomato soup. That is good fare for a Confederate soldier, especially two or three times a week. We could eat much better if someone brought in garden seeds from abroad. Vegetables deteriorate so quickly here that their stock runs out within two or three years. I am told beets do not produce seed here and cabbages form heads only in the first year. *[[The next sentence about locally grown vegetables is unclear.]]* Melons and grapes do well, and I have seen fairly good corn, cotton, and tobacco. Sweet and Irish potatoes grow well, but Irish potatoes have nearly disappeared because people depended on northern seed supplies and the blockade cut them off. If I owned land here, I would plant a vineyard. The soil seems suited to all kinds of grapes. Mustang grapes grow wild, and “French” grapes do fairly well in gardens. This is a fine country except for the mosquitoes.

We have done little around camp for three or four weeks, but this week we will have more lessons on the big guns. Artillery drill is easier to learn than infantry drill, but I dislike being around the guns in battle: they attract shot, bombs, and shrapnel. Shrapnel is a spherical shell filled with musket balls, with one thick side and one thin side. The thick side goes toward the powder; the thin side faces forward. When it bursts, the balls fly forward like a blunderbuss and can kill or disable everyone serving a gun. *[[The final phrase, referring to our cannon and Calcasieu, is illegible.]]*

Scan 076 07-076

Compulsory service and an unpopular inspection

[[Morrow?]] received some payment for *[[handling legal cases?]]* for angry Confederate men, but I do not know how much; it depended on the case. Nearly every kind of case came before him. Some *[[unclear designation]]* had themselves declared legally dead to avoid conscription. His work covered everything between that and desertion. If men were not forced to enter and remain in service, very few would still be in the ranks. I believe that if every unwilling man were discharged, Yankees would occupy every southern village within two months. It is strange what men can be made to do. Leaders drive them around as an ox driver drives his team. News from Virginia says Grant’s advance has been checked, that he is building fortifications, and that he will have to besiege Richmond. *[[The short report concerning Johnson and Sherman is unclear.]]*

Recently a captain from Magruder’s staff inspected us. He had more conceit than brains or sense. Grease on our guns dirtied his hands, which plainly troubled him. Afterward the men discussed him loudly enough for him to hear. Some called him *[[illegible]]*, others Dutch, finally deciding that he was Dutch and did not know his business. He asked Evans whether he allowed his men to talk like that. Evans, who had not listened to what they were saying, replied that he generally let them say what they pleased. The captain said he would report us as well armed, well drilled, and smart in appearance, but very badly disciplined. He will not want to inspect this company again soon. Inspectors often check our clothing and other supplies and report to headquarters, but I have never seen it do us any good. Fayette likes to tease me about my literary style, though I think I keep ahead of “Webster’s Unabridged.” Affectionately, George.

Scan 077 07-077

Filing slip: J. M. Bell to Susanna, August 31

To Susanna (Douglas) Bell from her husband, J. M. Bell. Sabine Pass, August 31 (date questioned on the filing slip).

Scan 078 07-078

Bell asks Sue for clothing and describes unpaid wages

Sabine Pass, August 31. My dear Sue,

Mr. *[[Erwin?]]* will go home this evening on a thirty-day assignment. He lives at *[[Steele?]]* and will pass our house. He has promised to deliver this letter and bring back any clothes you have for George and me. I badly need a pair of drawers. If you have *[[linen?]]*, please make a pair; *[[part of the passage about available cloth, timing, and a saddler is unclear]]*. If you have time, please knit me mittens or gloves. *[[The next lines about an item you made last winter are damaged and partly missing.]]* I hate to trouble you again for clothing when you already have enough to do for yourself and the children. The government ought to clothe its soldiers. It is too much to supply everything we wear and fight for nothing, since our wages are worse than nothing. Today we are owed twelve months' pay. I am nearly out of money. I wish I had time to send you *[[illegible]]*, which you could use; it is worthless here.

Things are much as usual. The weather is still very hot, and the mosquitoes are terrible—

Scan 079 07-079

Blockade, discipline, and missing letters

—and the day before yesterday we heard heavy firing toward Calcasieu. I have not learned the cause. The two captured vessels there have been disarmed; I hear one is loaded with cotton and will try to run the blockade. The Sachem is still here, waiting for a chance to escape. It will almost certainly be captured because the blockade is so strong: sometimes six vessels are anchored offshore.

I have heard nothing more about the charges against Colonel Griffin. I suppose nothing will happen until General Walker arrives. Griffin has become much more lenient since the charges were brought. He has reduced guard duty and now speaks to men in the street, something he never used to do. There are fewer men in the guardhouse than at any time in a year. I have had no letter for a long time. The last, dated August 6, came with George's. Have you stopped writing? I think the mail must be at fault and hope for a letter tomorrow. George says he needs only a pair of drawers. Excuse this hurried scrawl: I had only minutes to write, and the boat is nearly ready to leave. I will write again soon. *[[Unclear words.]]* My love to everyone. Your true and devoted husband, J. M. Bell.

Scan 080 07-080

Filing slip: Rebecca to George, July 23, 1864

To George Douglas from his sister Rebecca *[[Winniford?]]*, July 23, 1864.

Scan 081 07-081

Rebecca to George: hope for peace, July 23, 1864

Saturday, July 23, 1864. Dear brother George,

I received your welcome letter today. Such glorious news! That *[[reception?]]*—did their hearts not leap in response to those long-suppressed expressions of sympathy? Mine does! Will it be long before all despondent hearts leap with joy? I hope not, and almost believe it will be soon. But sooner or later, it will come. I trust that God’s providence will bring peace out of this great suffering: a calm, humble, thankful peace. This great nation, the most arrogant and quarrelsome on earth, has sinned grievously and grievously—

Scan 082 07-082

Rebecca hopes for reunion and an end to war

—has suffered for it. If we let experience teach us wisdom, we may once again be great, united, and happy. If reckless and wicked advice prevails, we know the bitter end will be destruction. I sincerely hope angry passions will subside, that reason and reflection will be heard, and that this unnatural war will become a thing of the past before this year ends.

We are all well. Thank God, Norvell is not in the war yet, and with God’s blessing he never will be.

Scan 083 07-083

Children, a journey to Eagle Pass, and crops

Mary and Elbert attend school, and Alice is nearly old enough. *[[Fanny?]]* is growing stronger, though *[[she?]]* is very backward. “Sweet Henry” is plump and well. I am healthy and heavier than you have ever seen me. Norvell is fairly healthy but very thin. He is on his way to Eagle Pass. Roberson Rocket drives one team of animals. “Anything to keep me out of this war,” Rob says. I expect them back by November 1 if nothing happens.

The crops are generally very good. I think there are two reasons. First, large groups of enslaved people were brought here from Arkansas and Louisiana—

Scan 084 07-084

Rebecca on enslaved labor, rain, and family news

—and their enslavers had to hire them out because they could not feed them. Second, unusually favorable weather has left the crops in excellent condition. One or two more good rains would be enough. Norvell had to go to Bowie for his load. He says it has rained more there and the large planters are growing only corn.

Keep your spirits up, George. The *[[three hundred?—meaning uncertain]]* are no myth, as far as I can judge. Laura has come over to attend tomorrow’s meeting at Lancaster. Everyone is well. Yours with love, Rebecca.

Scan 085 07-085

Filing slip: Rebecca Winniford to George, February 21, 1864

To George Douglas from his sister Rebecca (Douglas) Winniford, February 21, 1864.

Scan 086 07-086

Rebecca criticizes Confederate conduct, February 1864

[[February 21?]], 1864. Dear brother George,
I have sat down to [[illegible]], though I have nothing new or [[illegible]] to write. Things are fairly quiet [[illegible]]. Our bee hunters are back at their old occupation and have had success. *[[The discussion of a raid by Parsons's men is partly unreadable.]]* It has created more [[illegible]] and stirred up hostility and resistance that had previously been dormant. I think Parsons's men are splendid [[illegible]] for the Federals, whether they [[illegible]] or not. *[[Several damaged lines concern the army, going home, and southern citizens.]]* I do not think I am mistaken when I say that [[illegible]] of this country is that the Confederates are beating the South faster than the Yankees could.

Scan 087 07-087

Letters report desertion and poor rations

Yesterday I received letters from Bill Walker and George Winniford, dated the tenth and fifteenth of this month. They say officers get leave but ordinary soldiers do not, so the men take *[[“French furloughs”?—unauthorized leave]]*. *[[Some numbers and wording about men leaving together are unreadable.]]* Three companies *[[have?]]* left, and the rest await the growth of grass. Federal forces are at Fort Smith *[[illegible]]* Waldron, also waiting for grass. Texans go over to the Federals daily. They caught *[[illegible]]* and brought them back. *[[The next lines describe poor beef.]]* Four-year-old steers weigh 250 pounds. That is how things are. Perhaps treating the soldiers like men from the beginning would have produced a different result. Instead, they seemed to believe only force—

Scan 088 07-088

Reported casualties and a murder near Clarksville

—could get *[[illegible]]* out of them. Now even that seems to be failing. Tobe Hamilton was killed in the last fighting in Tennessee, and Frank *[[surname unreadable]]* is missing. The local boys were not in an *[[exposed?]]* position. Sam Watts has a *[[illegible]]* assignment to run the mill. *[[Several lines about equipment or arms are unreadable.]]* What is that *[[illegible]]*?

A horrible murder reportedly occurred near Clarksville. A group of *[[bushwhackers?]]* caught a man who had sold *[[illegible]]* for a large sum. *[[Part of the account of his money is unreadable.]]* They pulled out his fingernails and toenails to make him tell *[[illegible]]*, but obtained nothing. They let him go into the house, then called him out and shot him.

Scan 089 07-089

Competing reports and Rebecca's closing family news

Some say *[[illegible]]* Quantrill's men did it; others say men hiding in the brush did. McCullough has had a wagonload *[[illegible]]* sent in irons to Houston.

George, I know three *[[fair?]]* girls whom none of Parsons's men *[[illegible]]*. When the war ends, *[[illegible]]* introduce you. *[[Part of their description is unreadable.]]* Each is worth twenty “swamp angels.” I have written all day and am tired, so I must *[[illegible]]*. One more thing: Em Chapman has married Josh Pruitt, a “grass widower.” My little blue *[[illegible]]*, *[[part of the affectionate closing is unreadable]]*. Be a good boy. We are all well, and little Lucy's health is improving. Rebecca.

Scan 090 07-090

Filing slip: Rebecca Winniford to George, May 12, 1863

To George Douglas from his sister Rebecca Douglas Winniford, May 12, 1863.

Scan 091 07-091

Rebecca praises George's principles, May 12, 1863

At home, May 12, 1863. Brother George,

Yesterday I received your kind letter of April 20. I was glad to hear from you; I feared my own letter had not reached you. I am proud of your principles, George. Noble-minded people will respect you for them. When the clouds of war and the dark passions poisoning the air have passed, those principles will be a halo of glory around your head—or, better still, peace around your heart. They will never make you sigh with regret or blush with shame. If you die, they will be our only comfort. If you live, they will assure us that the hopes now gathering around you—

Scan 092 07-092

Rebecca's hopes for George and news of health at home

—will not end in bitter disappointment. I confess I feared for you: you were young, and so much advice and example pulled you the other way. If you overcome that pressure now, you will earn people's trust for the future. My deepest wish is that you pass through this ordeal with your mind unscarred and your body unharmed.

We are all reasonably well, and there is little illness nearby that I know of. Little Lucy is stronger and has started growing. Sister Laura was quite ill a week or more ago, but she was improving when I last heard. Early spring was far too wet; lately the weather has been suitable. The weeds seem to grow much faster than usual—

Scan 093 07-093

Buying steers and arranging repayment

We need an army at home to fight the weeds. They are formidable, and every available worker has been pressed into service.

May *[[15?]]*. I delayed finishing until I had news of Collins's beef steer. Today I heard that it is on his range and fat. Neighbors think \$45 for the trained steer and \$30 for the other would be fair prices. But if Collins wants more, pay \$80 or even \$90 rather than lose them. If you can pay him, it would help us greatly. We will repay Father whenever you or he asks for the money. I have not heard from Norvell lately; he is somewhere between here and Brownsville. Excuse the mistakes—I cannot help making them.

Scan 094 07-094

Marriages, harvest, and concern for prisoners

Old Johnny Chapman has married the widow Hogue; Jo Porter, the widow Strong; and George Clayton, Lavinia Andrews. Gurley's regiment has been dismounted and ordered east. Nearly all Stone's men are home preparing for the harvest. Wheat will ripen next week and looks better than usual; the corn is behind. We hear little reliable war news. The Arkansas Post prisoners have sent no word to this

neighborhood. People say six hundred have died, but I hope it is not that bad. I have nothing more to interest you. Take care of yourself: before long you will be needed to care for the old folks, and perhaps some young ones too. Be a good boy. Goodbye, Rebecca.

Scan 095 07-095

Envelope addressed to George at Sabine Pass

Mr. George Douglas, Sabine Pass, Texas. Company C, Griffin's Battalion, *[[unit abbreviation uncertain: T. V. I.?.]]*.

Scan 096 07-096

Filing slip: Rebecca to George, September 4, 1864

To George Douglas from his sister Rebecca Douglas Winniford, September 4, 1864.

Scan 097 07-097

Rebecca visits the Mullican neighborhood, September 4, 1864

Sunday, September 4, 1864. Brother George,

Your letter of August 14 arrived a few days ago. Your ideas about how long the war will last and what may affect it seem reasonable from your position. I will not debate them, but instead describe my visit to the Mullicans' neighborhood two weeks ago.

It was my second visit since they moved, and I took all the children. They were all well. Martha and Matilda are almost grown: attractive, modest girls. Henry and John had grown so much I hardly knew them. George and Orlando have died. Thomas and Monroe are in military service. We saw Thomas's wife. *[[Coz?]]* Mullican looks well, but Mrs. Mullican looks unwell. Mrs. Vaughn, Josh Vaughn, Ruth, and the children look very unwell.

Scan 098 07-098

A preacher interprets Revelation in wartime

William's children look well. Brother Robinson preached at the Mullicans' house on Saturday night and at the schoolhouse on Sunday. I saw Jimmy Myers and his wife. Jimmy looks the same; his wife is a large, attractive woman. On the way down we met a man with one arm, and another one-armed man stayed at the Mullicans' that night. The preacher was enthusiastic and seemed to know the Bible well. During a conversation about Revelation, he argued that the two witnesses in chapter 11 represent the Old and New Testaments. He believed their prophesying began with the rise of the Roman Catholic Church, and that its 1,260-year period ended when this war began.

Scan 099 07-099

Robinson's wartime prophecy, continued

He said the three and a half years during which their bodies would lie in the street are almost over. Then God's spirit will enter them and they will be taken into heaven—meaning, he believed, that the Testaments will regain their proper place in the church and in Christians' minds.

He interpreted the earthquake as the fall of a government, and the fall of a tenth of the city as the loss of the Church of Rome's power. He connected this with conscription, claiming it interfered with the Pope's

authority because the Pope opposed Catholics' participation in the war. He predicted that the Pope's political power would end in 1866. A period of changes would follow, the most important of which—

Scan 100 07-100

Rebecca's hope for peace through prophecy

—would be the spread of what he called true Christianity. Then the seventh angel would sound, and voices in heaven would proclaim that the kingdoms of the world had become the kingdoms of the Lord and his Christ, who would reign forever.

Brother Robinson explained it much better than I can write it, making everything fit neatly. I cannot remember enjoying anything so much. Imagine it: the Bible restored, the war ended, and Roman Catholicism brought down, along with the gradual disappearance of error and Christianity's final triumph! May it be so. Rebecca.

[[Final faint line unreadable.]]

Reading note. Rebecca's enthusiastic account contains anti-Catholic beliefs and predictions, presented here as her views, not as verified history or the editor's position.

Scan 101 07-101

Filing slip: Rebecca to George, December 11, 1864

To George Douglas from his sister Rebecca (Douglas) Winniford, December 11, 1864.

Scan 102 07-102

Rebecca considers moving to the Nueces, December 11, 1864

Sunday, December 11, 1864. Brother George,

I imagine you are settled in camp again, and perhaps a letter from me will relieve some lonely hours. We are all reasonably well, though my own health is poor. I hope winter will bring improvement.

It has been cold since Wednesday, and people are busy slaughtering hogs. My own prospects for pork are slim, probably because the only person who could look after the hogs is away.

Lately I have been thinking of moving. If I can manage it, I will leave in the spring and go down to the Nueces—

Scan 103 07-103

Cotton hauling, cattle, and a proposed home near Fort Ewel

Norvell has written asking me to come and bring the cattle if I can. That would be a major undertaking now: the cattle are scattered everywhere, and workers will be hard to find.

He intends to haul forty bales in the spring. Since he has to be away from home, he might as well make it pay. He currently has four teams on the road—or perhaps already at Brownsville—hauling thirty bales from San Antonio for nine cents a pound.

He will settle into winter quarters around Christmas. I expect to live near Fort Ewel, where he can stop for buttermilk as he passes. He has hired a "Dutchman" and two boys, besides Rob and another man. He bought two wagons, twelve pairs of oxen, a horse, revolvers, and Mexican blankets for \$800.

Scan 104 07-104

Rebecca asks whether the war can continue

I have not visited Father since Henry left, though I saw Laura the other day. Everyone was reasonably well. They expected Warren last night. I meant to visit today but was afraid to go out in the cold.

I do not know what to tell you about the girls, since you did not get to know my darlings. You must get to know them when you next come.

George, what about the war now? Will it ever end, and how? Will the army stay another four years—can it? After all the South’s boasts, what remains but surrender or destruction? How long before every man has a duty to think and act for himself? Those bigots willing to see our men killed, our country ruined, and our women and children starved should be quiet.

Scan 105 07-105

Fear of requisitions, drought, and a hoped-for adobe house

Price’s army has been driven back to Texas for the winter. I hear that for eighty miles south of the Red River they are taking horses two years old and older, mares, mules, oxen, and all the beef cattle. Some may come here for food. By next summer, I expect this area to feel all the horrors of war. Whether an enemy invades may hardly matter: unless peace comes, we will be stripped of everything. There is no use talking now; we are fighting.

It is still very dry. We have had enough rain to sprout the wheat, but not enough to fill the pools in the creek or replenish our little well. Write occasionally, and when we have built our adobe house, come and visit. Rebecca.

Scan 106 07-106

Filing slip: Winniford at Navassota, April 14, 1863

To Mr. George Douglas from *[[initials unclear]]* Winniford, Navassota, April 14, 1863. Later slip labels it “Civil War.”

Scan 107 07-107

Winniford’s hauling work at Navassota, April 14, 1863

Navassota, April 14, 1863. Mr. George Douglas,

Dear Sir, I am taking a few free moments this morning to write, and I hope you will reply. I am well.

Since early February I have been here at Navassota hauling corn for “Jeff Davis & Co.” They pay *[[partly unreadable phrase]]* for my labor. I have escaped that *[[snarl?]]* by agreeing to haul a load of cotton to Brownsville. They will pay \$10 per hundredweight: \$8 in Confederate money and \$2 in coin. I have two wagons. I can use one as I choose, so I will load it for a private individual at \$8 in gold.

Scan 108 07-108

Request to buy Collins’s oxen before the Brownsville trip

Yesterday morning I received a letter from home dated March 24. Everyone was well, and there was no important news. I will stay another ten or twelve days before leaving for Brownsville. J. H. Collins has a pair of oxen on the range at Danville. Please ask whether he will sell them and tell me his price. If it is

reasonable, I will send you the money to buy them.

Give my regards to J. M. Bell, Warren, and Collins. Write to me. Yours, *[[N. B.?]]* Winniford.

Scan 109 07-109

Damaged envelope and later March 5, 1864 filing slip

The damaged envelope is addressed to George Douglas, Company C, 21st Texas Volunteer Infantry. “Red Oak” and “March the” survive; the rest of the mailing date and destination are obscured. An annotation says “from Rebecca and Lizzie.”

A later filing slip identifies the letter as from his sister Rebecca Douglas Winniford, March 5, 1864.

Scan 110 07-110

Furloughs, desertions, and recruiting at Dallas, March 5, 1864

Brushy, March 5, 1864. No. 5. Brother George,

Your letter of February 21 and another of the same date arrived *[[details obscured]]*. We were glad and surprised to hear that the socks arrived quickly and safely. We are also glad that some *[[leave appears to be discussed, but text is damaged]]* may finally be granted. A remark about “a burning” and what prompted headquarters to consider the men’s happiness is partly unreadable.

[[First name obscured]] Walker is home on leave. He says the brigade numbered 1,500 in November and now has 700. Men are being granted leave; a partly obscured remark connects this with desertion and headquarters.

Father visited *[[name obscured]]*, who is home on short leave and hopes to be assigned to making shoes at Dallas. If he cannot obtain that assignment and must return to service, he wants to join your company with you, Joda, and Warren. Father asks you to consult Warren, find out whether the company is full, and write promptly. Send the names and locations of recruiting officers who are home.

The brigade is now scouting—or, as the writer puts it, helping friends “into the service.” The state has been divided into four districts; Dallas is headquarters for one. *[[Name obscured]]* feels fortunate to live nearby, but the writer doubts he will remain safe from recruitment. Coggins’s company, including Frank Farrer and Hal *[[surname obscured]]*, is home on ten days’ leave. *[[Further details obscured.]]* Harper Goodloe is home. I have not seen him, but people say he has grown a great deal. He had room to grow, did he not?

[[Marginal writing cannot be read securely.]]

Reading note. Much of this page is physically obscured. The readable version retains gaps rather than supplying names or completing damaged arguments.

Scan 111 07-111

Accusations of horse theft and hopes that cotton trade would end the war

It seems that at least some of Parsons’s men have taken to stealing. One of *[[name obscured]]* Branch’s or Beack’s sons *[[name syntax unclear]]*, and a son of old *[[name unreadable]]*, have been convicted. The punishment described is conscription into the infantry. One of *[[Mr. ?]]* Hull’s sons was involved but escaped; his whereabouts are obscured.

Our fashionable friend James Hancock was involved in the same business, but the horse he took had *[[partly obscured, apparently a “C. S.” brand]]*, which saved him. People say taking horses from “Feds”—meaning Unionist civilians—is *[[qualification obscured]]*, but the men sometimes take our own

people's horses. The writer reports an argument in Coggins's company: if the Yankees held Dallas, Confederate soldiers could take horses between *[[places obscured]]* to keep them from the enemy. Much of the argument is lost. The writer condemns the men's conduct and fears that by the war's end it will be a disgrace to be called one of Parsons's men.

Laura received a letter from Squire today, dated *[[obscured]]*, so the report that he deserted is mistaken. The writer distinguishes Coggins's company's connection to Parsons's regiment or brigade, but part of the explanation is lost. A Saturday-night addition mentions a severe cold and Mother's plans *[[obscured]]*.

Mother is busy making candles. The closing passage sends her reassurance: she believes the scouts moving through the country are connected with cotton for "old Jeff" and sales to the Yankees, and that completing this will end the war and bring the men home. *[[Important parts of the explanation are obscured.]]* Keep your spirits up and do not become *[[obscured]]*. Henry Morris told Father about cotton from the Texas coast and men being allowed *[[obscured]]* without conscription trouble. Harper Goodloe reports *[[obscured]]* from the mouth of the Red River; the last lines mention gunboats but cannot be read as a complete statement.

Reading note. The page contains accusations and wartime rumors. Extensive damage prevents a complete reading; none of the accusations has been independently verified in this transcription.